

Rome takes to the sea
In the 3rd century BCE the Carthaginians were far more experienced seamen than the Romans, but in the First Punic War they were defeated by Rome's superior military organization. One ingenious device that the Romans used was the corvus, a gangplank lowered onto enemy ships so the Roman legionaries could board them.

the Greek city-state of Athens used the silver produced by its richest mine to pay for a countering fleet. Victorious against Persia, Athens became the greatest naval power in the eastern Mediterranean, creating the world's first maritime empire. It was in the wars between the Greeks and Persians and between Athens and other Greek city-states that naval battles were for the first time fought on a large scale.

BUILDING BIGGER

The success of the Athenians was based upon the ramming power of the swift manoeuvrable trireme—the galley itself used as a weapon to sink enemy ships. This was a tactic that exploited the superior skills of Athenian oarsmen. States with more powerful armies and less skilled sailors opted for different tactics using different kinds of galley. From the 4th century BCE rulers such as Dionysius of Sicily, the Ptolemies in Egypt, and the Seleucids in Syria built larger vessels that were powered by vast numbers of less skilled oarsmen. These quinqueremes and even larger polyremes carried artillery in the form of siege machines, capable of hurling rocks at an enemy, and were packed with troops. Instead of the rapier thrusts of the trireme's ram, battles were won by bludgeoning the enemy's ships with firepower and boarding them with bodies of soldiers. When the rising Roman Republic came into conflict with the greatest naval power in the western Mediterranean, Phoenician Carthage, in the First Punic War in the 3rd century BCE, the stage was set for some of the largest naval battles ever fought, involving hundreds of thousands of men. Eventually Rome's willpower and resources made up for lack of naval experience and it was left as the sole dominant power in the Mediterranean.

CONTINUING THE GALLEY TRADITION

In galley warfare there was no sharp transition from the "ancient" to the "medieval" world. Rome's eastern successor state, the Byzantine Empire, fought Arab fleets from the 7th century in battles whose chief novelty was the use of "Greek fire" as an incendiary weapon. The tradition of galley warfare was maintained in the second millennium above all by the Italian city-states—chiefly Venice and Genoa—which financed fleets from the profits of trade with the Black Sea and the Levant and from selling their services to larger powers. As well as fighting pitched battles, their war galleys also engaged in regular commerce raiding. The Catalans and the sailors of Provence were also involved in wars fought for control of trade routes and for possession of islands and coastal bases.

